CODESCHOOL · GO-TO-MARKET RESEARCH

Competitors and channel

Who already sells CBSE CT&AI material and at what price, how schools buy, children's data law, the CodeSchool brand, and what to change before interviews start.

Deep research report · 6 November 2026

Built on 4 research threads plus the earlier market and CBSE research

Clickable contents, bookmarks and live source links

Repository: github.com/evolvian2026/CodeSchool

Summary

Sell CBSE's missing layer through booklists

Rs 179-630
price of a printed CBSE CT&AI book for 2026-27 (Oxford Class 8: Rs 305)

Rs 799
Uolo Tekie's book + platform + training, per student per year: the ceiling

30-40%
reported channel margin on private publishers' books (anecdotal)

0% vs 18%
GST on printed books vs digital licences (school can't reclaim the 18%)

May 2027
children's-data duties under the DPDP Act start, about six weeks into the first paid session

Moderate
brand risk: "CodeSchool" is free to use but descriptive and hard to own

CodeSchool's Rs 200-800 band is the right range, but competitors have already priced it. Printed CBSE CT&AI books for 2026-27 cost **Rs 179-630 a copy**: Oxford's Class 8 book is Rs 305, Goyal's Class 6 book Rs 270, and Uolo's Tekie.AI books sit on a Lucknow school booklist at Rs 579-629. Uolo's full Tekie programme (book, platform and teacher training) starts at **Rs 799 per student per year**. So the top of CodeSchool's range runs into its strongest rival, and the bottom leaves almost nothing after channel margins and GST. No vendor was found that sells all the pieces CBSE's free handbooks leave out: coding mapped to NCERT maths chapters, rubric-scored kits for the 40 project hours a year, hands-on AI for Classes 6-7 that needs few devices, and an observation journal. A few small vendors claim parts of it. Private schools buy this kind of material the way they buy books: publisher reps, specimen copies, and a booklist that parents pay for. CBSE allows vetted supplementary and digital material in Classes 1-8. Delhi's 2025 fee Act and 2026 directives in Delhi, Maharashtra, Rajasthan and J&K make a new "computer" or "AI" fee the riskiest way in, and ban forcing parents to buy from one vendor. The most viable compliant channel is a printed workbook (nil GST) with digital access that the school activates, listed on the school's published booklist and sold through ordinary booksellers. The duties for children's data under the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act are not yet in force. They start around **13-14 May 2027**, about six weeks into the first paid session, with penalties of up to Rs 200 crore. CodeSchool therefore has to be built from day one as a data processor working for the school. The name "CodeSchool" is unlikely to infringe any live mark, but it is descriptive and close to Bengaluru's Mycodeschool Labs. It should stay a working name and be replaced before anything is printed for the December booklist cycle.

The one-line recommendation

Replace a booklist line, don't add a fee. Sell a printed pack with school-activated access through the booklist (Rs 449 for Classes 3-5, Rs 599 for Classes 6-8), keep the account owned by the school so CodeSchool stays a data processor, and choose a coined brand before specimens are printed in December. All prices are recommendations to test in interviews.

Research findings, not legal or tax advice. Data-protection, GST and trademark points need an Indian lawyer, a tax adviser or a trademark attorney before acting.

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These are research findings, not legal or tax advice. Several items rest on secondary sources and need an Indian lawyer, a tax adviser or a trademark attorney before CodeSchool acts on them; each one is flagged where it appears. Vendor statements are claims, not verified facts.

1. Printed CT&AI books cost Rs 180-630, and Tekie sets the ceiling at Rs 799

Publishers moved fast, and most sell print without a digital layer

Within six months of CBSE's April 2026 launch, the CT&AI shelf filled with print. **Oxford University Press India** has a six-book "Computational Thinking and Artificial Intelligence" series for Classes 3-8. The Class 8 book is **Rs 305** for 152 pages. OUP pitches it as an "all-in-one solution" for the mandatory curriculum, but the product page mentions no digital add-on, projects, rubrics or coding (OUP India, Class 8). **Goyal Brothers'** "Think Smart" Class 6 book costs **Rs 270** (BuyBooksIndia), and Arihant lists a Class 6 textbook (Arihant).

Below them is a long tail. Thinking Juggernaut sells CT workbooks at Rs 499 and AI workbooks at Rs 599, though its own page contradicts itself on MRP (Thinking Juggernaut). A Vidhi Singhal Class 7 title costs Rs 295 (Amazon.in). Amazon sellers offer "Student Handbook" editions at **Rs 179-189** (Amazon.in, Class 7). These share a title with CBSE's free handbooks and carry a publication date three months before CBSE's own first edition, so treat them as possible unofficial reprints.

STEMpedia charges Rs 440-480 for its "Skillful Minds" books. Each comes with 3,000 PictoBlox AI credits, entry to the Codeavour competition and 25 lab activities. Its stated alignment is to CBSE's Coding skill subject, not CT&AI (STEMpedia).

Product (2026-27)	Classes	Price per student (Rs)	What it includes beyond print
Amazon "Student Handbook" (Tovira)	7-8	179-189 (MRP 300-370)	Nothing
Goyal "Think Smart"	6	270	None stated
Orange "Artificial Intelligence" (2025 ed.)	6	289 (MRP 340)	None stated
Vidhi Singhal "Mastering CT and AI"	7	295	None stated
OUP "Computational Thinking and AI"	3-8	305 (Class 8)	None on product page
STEMpedia "Skillful Minds"	4-8	440-480	PictoBlox AI credits, competition, certificate; needs devices
Thinking Juggernaut workbooks	3-8	499-599	AI kit with online assessment and teacher module (kit unpriced)
Uolo "Tekie.AI – Accelerate"	4-8	579-629 (booklist)	Part of Tekie programme
Uolo Tekie programme	1-8	**from 799 per year**	Coding platform, teacher portal, auto-graded homework, training

Sources: as cited in the text, and the CMS Lucknow booklist, Kitabkopy and Uolo.

Uolo is the benchmark rival, and it is already replacing the computer book

Uolo's Tekie is the closest thing to what CodeSchool plans. For **Rs 799 per student per year** it bundles storytelling course books, a coding platform usable from home, hands-on projects, a teacher portal with auto-graded homework and attendance, a test-paper generator and year-round teacher training. Uolo claims "500K+ students from 1000+ schools" (Uolo Tekie). That page is undated and does not mention CBSE CT&AI.

The more telling evidence is a booklist. City Montessori School, Lucknow prescribes "Tekie.AI – Accelerate" for 2026-27 under a single heading, **"Computational Thinking & ICT"**, at Rs 579 for Grade 4 rising to Rs 629 for Grades 6-8 (CMS booklist). Uolo has merged the old computer book and the new CT&AI requirement into one line on the booklist. A DPS-branded 2026-27 booklist shows what that line usually holds: a "Computers" book for Classes 4-8 from incumbents such as Orange, Ratna Sagar or Mindpick (DPS booklist).

The rest of the school-facing market sells at a different scale or hides its prices. **LEAD Group** sells TECHBOOK and a coding programme inside a whole-school system for affordable private schools (Education21; APAC News Network).

Scaleopal Labs claims to cover all seven CBSE CT&AI competency areas, with an engineer on campus for every session and an unexplained "zero-cost model", and publishes no prices (Scaleopal Labs). **Atal Tinkering Lab (ATL) vendors** such as Avishkaar and STEMROBO sell labs at lakh-rupee scale: one Kendriya Vidyalaya ATL tender is estimated at Rs 6.5 lakh for 60 students, about **Rs 10,800 per student** (KVS tender). Other edtechs, including Next Education, Extramarks, Codingal for Schools and Tinkerly, quote prices only on request. The public price ladder therefore has only two firm rungs, print at Rs 180-630 and Tekie at Rs 799, with labs far above both.

The free layer covers content, so CodeSchool cannot charge for content

CBSE's own package costs schools nothing. It comprises twelve free student and teacher handbooks, a framework that recommends free tools such as Scratch, Teachable Machine and Machine Learning for Kids, and free training: more than **450 one-day district sessions** had been scheduled by August 2026, and the 3030 Eklavya series with IIT Gandhinagar is free apart from an optional Rs 200 certificate (EdTechReview). Two outside programmes add free curriculum. ACM India's CSpathshala offers **200+ lesson plans under CC BY** (CSpathshala). The Raspberry Pi Foundation's Experience AI launched in India on **13 July 2026** through the University of Southampton Delhi, with lesson plans, videos and assessments for public and private schools (University of Southampton Delhi). Free material covers puzzles and AI awareness well. It does not provide ready projects, rubrics or progress records.

The gaps CBSE left are still mostly unclaimed

The CBSE handbook review found that the twelve books contain **no coding, no project materials and no rubrics**, and that only Class 8 has hands-on AI (Class 8 Student Handbook). As of April 2026 CBSE still had not published marks weightage or a report-card format, and called project rubrics "coming soon" (EdTechReview). The table below compares those gaps with what vendors claim.

What CBSE's books lack	Who claims to fill it	How strong the claim is
Coding tied to each NCERT maths chapter's puzzles	Nobody found. STEMpedia teaches coding, but against the Coding skill subject and with devices	**Open**
Briefs, rubrics and exemplars for the two 20-hour projects a year in Classes 6-8	PiyushAI claims teacher manuals with assessment rubrics. Scaleopal claims it through on-campus engineers	Weak: PiyushAI lists no prices and its portal is "Coming 2026" (PiyushAI); Scaleopal is a staffed-lab model
Teacher scripts for the AI chapters	PiyushAI (manuals); Thinking Juggernaut (online teacher module)	Unverified; no samples inspected
Hands-on AI for Classes 6-7 on few devices	Nobody found	**Open**. Only 36.5% of schools have functional desktops: 63.2% of private unaided schools and 25.5% of government schools (EdTechReview)
Observation journal and report-card format	Tekie's auto-grading and teacher portal come closest	**Open** for a CBSE-competency journal

Two caveats apply. First, no vendor's samples were inspected, so a claim of "rubrics" or "projects" may or may not match CBSE's project list. Second, the window is closing. CBSE could publish its rubric list at any time, and the absence of CT&AI titles from Kips, Eupheus, Madhubun and other incumbents this year most likely means they will arrive for 2027-28. That is an inference from their pattern, not a sourced announcement.

2. Booklists, not fee heads, are the compliant way into private schools

Schools buy CT material the way they buy books

The selling motion is the publisher's. Sales reps hand specimen copies to teachers and principals (Ashirwad Publication). Specimens are often tied to the subject a teacher teaches and need a principal's authorisation (Oswal Publishers). Publishers also work through teacher events and conference exhibitions (Oswaal Books). About half of Indian K-12 students are in private schools, and most private-school students buy their own textbooks (EY-Parthenon / API). The money in this channel is the parent's, passed through a list the school prescribes.

That channel runs on margins. Booksellers reportedly earn 15-20% on NCERT books but **30-40% on private publishers' books** (Journey Line). A Kashmir official put the figure for books sold on school premises at 40-60% (Kashmir Vision, 2018). The price gap draws public anger: a 256-page NCERT book costs Rs 65 against Rs 305 for a 167-page private title (NewsBlaze). Haryana cracked down in Sirsa after complaints about publisher deals (The Tribune). All these margin figures are anecdotal, regional and partly old.

Three things about the buying process are unknown. The first is the decision calendar. Older sources put booklist finalisation in December-January for an April session (Business Standard), but this round found no current confirmation. The second is how the decision is split between owner, principal and coordinator. The third is whether Sahodaya school clusters act as a buying channel. All three are things the interviews must answer.

CBSE allows supplementary digital material in Classes 1-8, with conditions

After its 2024 revision, CBSE **requires** NCERT textbooks in Classes 9-12. For Classes 1-8 it only **"strongly advises"** NCERT or SCERT books. It also tells schools that "extreme care should be taken while using supplementary material, digital content as well as books of private publishers". Such material must align with NCF-SE, and schools must publish their book lists online with a declaration signed by the manager and principal (Careers360, Aug 2024). Careers360 called the text a "proposed amended rule", so its final form should be checked against the current bye-laws.

Separately, CBSE circular 10/2017 told schools to "desist from the unhealthy practice of coercing parents" into buying books and stationery from the school or from selected vendors (CBSE circular, 19 Apr 2017). The Delhi High Court held in 2018 that selling books in school shops is not commercialisation when there is no coercion (Careers360). No CBSE guidance specific to edtech or digital purchasing was found.

For CodeSchool, that means a Classes 3-8 workbook or licence is legally usable if three things hold. It must be framed as NCF-SE-aligned supplementary material. It must appear by name and price on the school's signed website list. And parents must be able to buy it somewhere other than the school.

State fee laws make a new "AI fee" the hardest thing to add

States are tightening what schools can charge. Delhi's **School Education (Transparency in Fixation and Regulation of Fees) Act, 2025** came into force on **10 December 2025** (Delhi DoE order). It limits schools to defined fee heads and bans "miscellaneous" collections, requires a School Level Fee Regulation Committee (SLFRC) with parent members at every school, gives parents what is effectively a veto over fee hikes, and orders excess fees refunded within 20 working days (News on AIR). Under Delhi High Court interim orders, schools must keep charging 2025-26 fees until the new committees approve new structures (NewKerala). On 1 April 2026 Delhi also told private schools not to force parents to buy books from specific vendors, and to post the year's book list online (Careers360).

Other states point the same way. **Maharashtra** reportedly ordered schools to resolve, from 2026-27, not to force purchases from specific shops, though the only source is a partisan outlet (Sanatan Prabhat). **Rajasthan** has a 2016 fee Act (India Code), and newer guidelines reportedly freeze fee hikes until 2027 and confirm that parents may buy books in the open market (India.com). **J&K**'s fee committee told schools not to compel the purchase of private-publisher textbooks (Greater Kashmir). In **Ludhiana**, parents sought a **Rs 6.3 crore refund** of excess fees that included "smart class" charges (The Tribune), which shows exactly how a digital-product fee unravels. Gujarat, Maharashtra's 2011 fee Act, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Uttar Pradesh were not researched.

This reverses part of the earlier market report. That report recommended a per-student fee "collected through school fees". On current evidence, a new fee head is the route most exposed to committee vetoes, frozen fees and refund orders.

GST favours print, and the school cannot recover tax on software

Printed books are nil-rated (Disytax). From 22 September 2025, exercise books and notebooks moved to nil as well (Business Today). The GST exemption for services supplied *to* schools (Entry 66 of Notification 12/2017-CT(Rate)) covers only a narrow list, such as transport, catering, security and exam-related services (TaxGuru). Software licences are taxed: the Odisha Authority for Advance Ruling (AAR) held that Coursera user licences supplied to a state authority were a licensing service taxable at **18%**, not an education service (LiveLaw Biz).

Plan for 18% on any digital licence. A Rs 599 tax-inclusive price would carry about Rs 91 of GST. Because a school's fees to its own students are exempt, it cannot claim back that input tax. A printed workbook would be nil-rated. But a book bundled with an access code may be treated as a mixed supply and taxed at the higher rate, so the pack's structure needs a tax adviser before pricing is printed.

The channel ranking

Channel	Who pays	Compliance exposure	Economics	Verdict
Booklist pack: printed workbook plus school-activated access, sold through booksellers and online	Parent	Low, if parents can buy it outside the school and it is on the signed website list	30-40% channel margin; print nil-rated	**Lead channel**
School-budget licence, paid from an existing approved head or the school's own funds	School	Lowest for parents	18% GST the school cannot recover; no margin for the school; hard to sell at mid tiers	**Second channel**, for premium and chain schools
New fee head ("AI fee", "smart class fee")	Parent, via fees	High: needs SLFRC or committee approval; Delhi fees frozen; refund precedent	Clean collection if approved	**Avoid**
Direct to parents, on school referral	Parent	Low on fees; heavy on data (CodeSchool becomes a data fiduciary)	Low conversion expected (no data)	Later add-on
Government (GeM, Samagra Shiksha ICT)	State	Tender rules	Hardware-led, multi-year maintenance contracts	Not relevant to private CBSE schools (DoSEL)

One question has never been tested in court: whether an access code sold *only* through the school counts as a single vendor. Making the pack available from booksellers and online sidesteps it.

3. Children's data rules switch on in May 2027, six weeks into the first paid session

Nothing binds the product today, but everything binds the pilot

The DPDP Act 2023 is coming into force in phases. Only the institutional parts are live now.

Date	What takes effect
27 Jun 2022 (already in force)	CERT-In directions: report specified cyber incidents within **6 hours**; keep ICT logs for 180 days (Ahuva)
13 Nov 2025	DPDP Rules notified as G.S.R. 846(E); Data Protection Board and institutional provisions commence (Juris Eagle)
5 Oct 2026	Removal of Difficulties Order: two clarifying wording fixes, no new duties or deadlines (S.S. Rana; SCC Online)
About 13-14 Nov 2026	Consent Manager registration framework (dcomply)
About 13-14 May 2027	Everything substantive: notice, consent, children's data (Section 9 and Rule 10), security, breach notification, retention, rights, cross-border transfers and penalties (same sources)

A January 2026 proposal to shorten the 18-month runway to 12 months had not been notified as of October 2026 (Business Standard). Sources disagree on whether the final phase starts on 13 or 14 May 2027, and on some rule numbers, so both should be checked against the Gazette. The practical point does not depend on that detail: **an April 2027 pilot will cross into full DPDP obligations within weeks**. Consent collected before then must already meet the Rule 10 standard, or it will have to be collected again.

What the Act demands for under-18 learners

Every CodeSchool user is a "child", because the Act defines a child as anyone under 18. Section 9 then imposes three duties (dpdpa.com, Section 9). Under **9(1)** the data fiduciary must obtain verifiable consent from a parent before processing any child's data. Under **9(2)** it must not process data in ways "likely to cause any detrimental effect on the well-being of a child", a duty with no exemption at all (Juris Eagle). Under **9(3)** it must not engage in "tracking or behavioural monitoring of children or targeted advertising directed at children". The maximum penalties are **Rs 200 crore** for breaching the children's-data duties and **Rs 250 crore** for failing to keep data secure (amlegals).

Rule 10 explains how to verify a parent. The fiduciary may rely on reliable identity and age details it already holds, or on a virtual token from an authorised entity such as DigiLocker (dpdpa.com, Rule 10). A school already holds parent details from admission, so it can verify against its own records. A platform meeting a parent for the first time would need the token route (Juris Eagle). One advocate advises edtechs to drop student-led OTP sign-up entirely, to avoid keeping parents' ID documents, and to keep children's data out of analytics and machine-learning pipelines (LiveLaw, 20 Oct 2026).

The school's exemption probably does not cover CodeSchool

Item 3 of the Fourth Schedule exempts an educational institution from the consent and tracking bans, but only for tracking and behavioural monitoring for its educational activities or for the safety of its enrolled children (dpdpa.com, Fourth Schedule). Whether that exemption extends to a vendor working for the school is "expressly unsettled". The Schedule names school *transport* providers specifically, which can be read as excluding other vendors (Juris Eagle). Commentators also doubt that commercial edtechs count as "educational institutions" at all (MediaNama).

The prevailing analysis still gives CodeSchool a clear way through. If CodeSchool processes data only on the school's instructions, the school is the fiduciary and carries the consent duty, and CodeSchool is a processor bound by a Section 8(2) contract. A platform that deals with families directly is a fiduciary in its own right, with no school exemption to rely on (LiveLaw). Any secondary use, such as marketing to parents, profiling students, cross-school analytics or model training, makes the vendor a fiduciary for that use. Targeted advertising is never permitted, and learning analytics is unsettled: it could count as exempt "monitoring for educational activities" or as ordinary processing that needs consent (Juris Eagle).

Design implications: build a processor, not a platform

The legal analysis translates into a small set of product rules; these are the research team's inferences, not legal advice. **Identity** should rest on a school-issued roll number or pseudonymous ID plus class and section, with the name-to-ID mapping kept at the school or in a separate, access-restricted store, and with no photos, addresses, Aadhaar numbers, dates of birth or student-created accounts. **Consent** should be issued and collected by the school, verified against its admission records, with CodeSchool supplying the notice text and a bilingual consent form. **Progress data** needs the most care, because placement checks and mastery gates are the core of the level design: they should record scores against curriculum items that a teacher can see, not behavioural profiles, with no streaks, engagement nudges or third-party analytics and advertising SDKs, and with product telemetry kept aggregate or anonymised. Session design should also respect PRAGYATA, the Ministry of Education's digital-education guidelines, which allow up to two sessions of 30-45 minutes a day for Classes 1-8 (PIB).

AI features should never train on identifiable student data, should call providers configured for zero retention under contract, and should put generated content in front of a teacher first; an AI tutor that builds a persistent model of each learner should wait for a lawyer's view on whether it is "behavioural monitoring". **Infrastructure** belongs in an Indian cloud region, with security logs kept for one year under the DPDP Rules and 180 days under CERT-In. The **breach playbook** must cover the 6-hour CERT-In report, prompt notice to the school, and the school's own duty to send the Board a detailed report within 72 hours (MediaNama). **Marketing** should avoid outcome claims, in line with the 2024 CCPA guidelines on coaching advertisements (Khaitan & Co), and should never use children's photos or testimonials without separate consent.

The booklist channel creates a real conflict with these rules. If a parent buys a pack and activates the code by signing up, CodeSchool has a direct relationship with the family and becomes a fiduciary. The way out is to treat the access code as an **entitlement, not an account**. The school uploads its class rosters, students are provisioned under the school's instructions, and the code only unlocks seats. Any parent view runs through the school's identity records. The paid home-practice tier proposed in the earlier market report would make CodeSchool a fiduciary needing a DigiLocker consent flow. It should wait until 2027-28 and a lawyer's sign-off.

Six questions need an Indian data-protection lawyer before a pilot contract is signed: whether CodeSchool is only a processor or also a fiduciary for the parent view, analytics and AI features; whether adaptive levelling counts as barred behavioural monitoring; whether consent collected before May 2027 stays valid; what the school data processing agreement (DPA) must contain, including liability caps sized against crore-scale penalties; what anonymisation standard applies to cross-school analytics; and whether the Gazette's rule numbers and dates match what commentators report.

4. "CodeSchool" is free to use but nearly impossible to own

The best-known prior user is gone. Pluralsight bought Orlando's Code School in January 2015 for **$36 million** (TechCrunch). User posts suggest the brand was folded into Pluralsight around 2018 (Elixir Forum).

Both US applications for the plain words "CODE SCHOOL" are **abandoned**. The original company's own application disclaimed both "CODE" and "SCHOOL" (Justia, 85929456; Justia, 86724562). Silicon Valley Code School also disclaims "CODE SCHOOL" (Justia, 88619982). Active neighbours in the US include theCoderSchool, a kids' franchise (Franchising.com), and The Coding School, a non-profit (Justia).

In India, public aggregators showed no company or trademark named "CodeSchool". The nearest match is **Mycodeschool Labs Private Limited**, incorporated in Bengaluru in 2013 and linked to the "mycodeschool" programming-education brand (Tofler). The most telling Indian precedent is a refusal: "CODING SCHOOLING" (device), application 5133442 in Class 41, was **refused** (RegisterKaro). Meanwhile "CODING CLUB" (device) is shown as registered (RegisterKaro). That pattern suggests a distinctive device or a coined element is what gets a descriptive phrase through.

The risk is therefore **moderate overall**. The risk of infringing someone else's mark is low to moderate: nothing live was found, but the Indian register was not searched directly, and Mycodeschool works in the same field. The risk to protecting the brand is high, because the name describes the service. Writing it as one word is unlikely to change that. CodeSchool could not stop a competitor calling itself "XYZ Code School", and would struggle to defend against lookalikes. The exact-match .com is a legacy Pluralsight-era domain whose status could not be checked.

Using the name in interviews is harmless, because a working name in an introduction letter creates no brand equity and no exposure. The cost of a change rises sharply once a name is printed on specimen copies and published in school booklists from December. Renaming the GitHub repository later is trivial.

5. Recommendations for the 16 November start

Price and packaging: replace a booklist line rather than add one

The evidence turns the Rs 200-800 hypothesis into three concrete packages. All prices are recommendations to test, not validated figures.

Package	Contents	Recommended price	Net to CodeSchool	Positioning
Classes 3-5 Practice Pack	Slim printed level workbook indexed by NCERT maths chapter; school-activated access to coding levels; printable unplugged kits; observation journal	**Rs 449 MRP** per student per year	About Rs 270-315 after a 30-40% channel margin, before any GST on the digital part	Below Tekie.AI books (Rs 579-599 at these grades), above OUP (Rs 305), with coding and a journal OUP lacks
Classes 6-8 Projects and AI Pack	Workbook plus two rubric-scored project kits a year; projector-mode ML labs for Classes 6-7; scripts for the AI chapters	**Rs 599 MRP**	About Rs 360-420	At Tekie.AI's book price and below Tekie's Rs 799 floor; covers the 40 project hours nobody else fills
School licence (no student print)	Teacher and projector mode, class dashboard, report-card export	**Rs 299 + 18% GST** per student (Rs 353 to the school)	Rs 299	For premium and chain schools that pay from their own budget

The Rs 200 anchor should be dropped as a list price. It sits below the cheapest print book and leaves about Rs 130 before GST once a 35% margin is taken. Rs 800 should not be the list price either, because that is exactly where Tekie's full programme starts. The strongest framing is to **replace the existing Computers book line in Classes 3-8** with a single "Computers and CT&AI" pack, as Uolo has done at CMS. Replacing a line keeps the parent's total booklist bill roughly flat. That matters in states where fee and booklist increases draw scrutiny.

Channel: lead with the booklist, keep the fee head off the table

Sell the packs through the publisher motion. That means specimen copies to coordinators and teachers by December, a teacher workshop, and availability through two or more booksellers and online, so no parent is forced to buy from one source. Give each school a ready text for its signed website booklist that describes the pack as NCF-SE-aligned supplementary material for CBSE CT&AI. Offer the school licence only where a school confirms it pays from an existing head or its own budget. Never propose a new fee head. Before printing, get tax advice on whether the workbook and access code should be priced as separate supplies to protect the nil rating on print.

Compliance: ship the processor architecture in the pilot build

The pilot build should include roster-based provisioning with roll-number IDs, a school-issued bilingual DPDP notice and consent form verified against admission records, no student self-registration and no third-party SDKs, AI calls set to zero retention, hosting in an Indian region, a one-page data-protection pledge for principals, a school DPA template drafted with an Indian lawyer, and a breach playbook covering the 6-hour and 72-hour duties. Defer the paid parent tier. Being demonstrably ready for May 2027 also gives CodeSchool something to sell that no competitor's public page mentions.

Brand: decide before specimens are printed

Keep "CodeSchool" as the internal codename and in the current introduction letter. During the interview weeks, shortlist three to five coined names and have a trademark attorney search IP India for each in Classes 9 (apps), 16 (printed workbooks), 28 (kits), 41 (education) and 42 (SaaS), together with any filings by Mycodeschool Labs, MCA company names, domains and app-store titles. Settle the name by early December so specimens carry the final brand. File it as a word mark plus a logo, and use "code school" only descriptively, if at all.

Interviews: test the channel, the competitor baseline and data readiness

The current guides test need and price, but they barely touch how money actually moves, which competitors schools have already adopted, or what schools need on data. The changes below fix that without lengthening any interview by more than five minutes.

Guide and question	Change	Why
Principal Q2 (who decides)	Add: "Who signs the book list that goes on your website, and does a fee committee review it?"	CBSE's signed-list rule; SLFRC and committee approval
Principal Q4 (current products)	Make it concrete: "Which Computers and CT&AI books are on your 2026-27 list, from which publisher, at what price? Did you consider Oxford, Goyal or Tekie?"	Establishes the Rs 270-630 baseline school by school
Principal Q8 (fees or budget)	Replace with: "Which fee heads do you charge, such as computer, smart class or activity? Would a new product go on the book list, come out of an existing fee, or come out of the school budget? Has a fee committee or parent body ever questioned a charge?"	A new fee head is the riskiest route; this finds the real payment path
Principal Q9 (price anchors)	Anchor on packages, not bare numbers: "a Rs 300 school licence plus GST", "a Rs 450-600 workbook with app access on the book list", "an Rs 800 book-plus-platform with training". Then ask: "Would it replace your current computer book or sit alongside it?"	Matches the competitor price ladder; tests the replace-a-line framing
Principal, new	"How do publishers usually work with you: specimen copies, training, terms? By when must specimens reach you for next session?" Ask neutrally and do not ask about commissions directly	Confirms the December specimen deadline and margin expectations
Principal, new	"Do parents buy books from the school, a named shop, or anywhere they like?"	Anti-coercion exposure under CBSE and state rules
Coordinator Q11 (vendors)	Prompt named vendors (Oxford, Goyal, Uolo Tekie, STEMpedia, LEAD, Thinking Juggernaut, PiyushAI, Scaleopal) and record what was offered and the price	Fills the pricing gaps the desk research could not
Coordinator Q5 (assessment)	Add: "CBSE hasn't published marks weightage or a report-card format. What will appear on this year's report card?"	Tests the journal and report-card opening
Coordinator, new	"When an app needs student logins, who creates them and what details does the school share? Does the school take parent consent for apps? Has anyone raised the DPDP Act?"	Processor design; consent through admission records; data as a buying reason
Computer teacher, new	"How do students log in to any platform today: roll number, school email, parent phone?"	Feasibility of roster and roll-number IDs
Parents Q5 (trust)	Add: "Would you be comfortable with the school giving an app your child's class and roll number? Do you use DigiLocker?" and "Where did you buy this year's books?"	Consent acceptability; the DigiLocker route; open-market buying

Three hypotheses should join the tally.

#	Hypothesis	Supported if	Kill signal
H11	Schools will put a CT&AI workbook with app access on the booklist	Principals name the booklist as the route for computer and CT material	New booklist items are blocked and there is no school budget
H12	Schools will replace their current Computers book with a combined pack	Principals name the book they would drop	Schools are locked into a multi-year series
H13	Student-data handling matters to buyers	Coordinators raise data or consent unprompted, or have vendor requirements	Nobody cares; compliance is then a cost, not a selling point

Extend the decision rule so that a December pilot offer also needs H11 to hold in at least half of mid- and premium-tier schools.

6. Conclusion

The research changes what CodeSchool is selling. The question is no longer whether a school will pay for something CBSE gives away. Schools already pay, through parents, for a computer book on the booklist. The question is whether CodeSchool can take that line. Uolo has shown it can be done, and Oxford has shown how cheap the print-only alternative is. CodeSchool's opening is to be the only pack that fills the gaps CBSE admits to: coding a child builds, projects a teacher can mark, AI work that runs on one projector, and a journal that fills the report-card gap. It must be priced between the Rs 305 book and the Rs 799 platform.

The less obvious finding is a conflict between channel and law. The channel that suits regulators and buyers, a parent-paid booklist item, is the one most likely to turn CodeSchool into a data fiduciary, the moment a parent signs up directly. The fix costs little if it is designed in now: the code is a book entitlement, and the account belongs to the school. Three deadlines now converge on the same few months: booklist and specimen deadlines in December and January, the CBSE rubric list that could arrive at any time, and DPDP's full commencement in May 2027. A brand decision and a processor-first build therefore belong in the interview weeks, not after them.

7. Method, caveats and companion documents

- **Method.** Four parallel research threads (competitors and pricing; school buying and CBSE/state rules; children's data law; brand availability) wrote cited notes, synthesised with the earlier market report, the US vs CBSE report, the CBSE handbook review and the interview plan.
- **Not verified directly.** No vendor samples were inspected; larger edtechs quote school prices only on request. The 2024 CBSE textbook rule may be a proposed amendment. Margin figures are anecdotal and partly old. MeitY's DPDP Rules text came via mirrors and law-firm commentary (13 vs 14 May 2027 and rule numbers need the Gazette). IP India, USPTO, MCA, WHOIS and app stores were not searched directly.
- **Gaps.** The current booklist calendar and who signs it; Sahodaya and chain procurement; fee laws in Gujarat, Maharashtra (2011), Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and UP; whether a workbook bundled with an access code keeps nil GST.
- **Dates.** Facts are current to 6 November 2026 unless dated otherwise; prices were seen 1-6 November 2026.

Companion documents

Document	What it adds
Research notes for this report	The four cited note files behind every section
CodeSchool Research Pack (PDF)	When programming starts in India, the level framework, market, and the full CBSE review
US vs CBSE: CT and AI (PDF)	How the US teaches CT and AI and what India can improve
School interview plan	Hypotheses H1-H10 and guides; section 5 of this report proposes changes and H11-H13
Interview Field Kit and Research Tracker	Tools to test these conclusions with 15-20 schools